The Pledge of the Tathāgata's Glory

Mahāsannipātād Mahāyānasūtrāt Tathāgataśrīsamaya-nāma-mahāyānasūtra · Toh 230 · Derge Kangyur

འདུས་པ་ཆེན་པ་ཐེག་པ་ཆེན་པའོ་མདོ་སོ་སྡེས་དཔེ་བཞིན་གཤགས་པའི་དཔལ་གྱི་ཉམ་ཚིག་ཅས་བཀྲ་ཐགེ་པ་ཆོ་ན་པའོ་མདོ།

The Pledge of the Tathāgata's Glory, known in Sanskrit as the Tathāgataśrīsamaya and in Tibetan as De bzhin gshegs pa'i dpal gyi dam tshig, is a Great Vehicle sūtra that presents itself as belonging to the Great Assembly, the Mahāsannipāta, a large collection of Mahāyāna discourses. It opens in the classic sūtra manner, with the Buddha dwelling on a mountain described as the abode of sages, surrounded by countless śrāvakas and by a great gathering of bodhisattvas who have come from many buddha realms, setting the stage for a teaching on the pledge and glory of the tathāgatas. It is Toh 230 in the Kangyur, where it is placed among the general sūtras of the Mahāyāna, the class of discourses attributed to the Buddha that set out the bodhisattva path and the qualities of awakened beings.

In the language of India: ma ha san ni pā tād ma hā yā na sū trātat thā ga ta śrī sa ma ya na nā ma ma hā yā na sū tra

In the language of Tibet: From the Great Assembly, the Collection of Great Vehicle Sūtras: the Great Vehicle sūtra called The Pledge of the Tathāgata's Glory.

The first section.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling on Mount Thersgra, the abode of the sages and the seat of the munis, the place where the boundless and limitless Bṛhaspati of the Great Brahmā received his prophecy. He was together with a great Saṅgha of śrāvakas, namely the Blessed One's śrāvakas beyond counting, and with a great Saṅgha of bodhisattvas, namely bodhisattva mahāsattvas beyond counting who had gathered there from all the buddhafields of the ten directions.

At that time, in that great gathering of the assembly, the great goddess Śrī was seated not far from the Blessed One in order to listen to the Dharma. Then the great goddess Śrī rose from her seat, joined her palms and bowed in the direction of the Blessed One, and said to the Blessed One:

"Venerable Blessed One, there are beings here who cannot be carried across the ocean of birth by the ship of the meritorious deeds that arise from generosity. Why is that? In this afflicted buddhafield, marked by the five degenerations, most sentient beings are devoid of anything that could be called merit. For that reason and on that account, the bodhisattva mahāsattvas give rise to great compassion here for sentient beings.

"Here there are sentient beings who teach that there is no cause, who are without wealth, who suffer and are worn down by their seeking, and who toil to no purpose. These cannot be brought to maturity without the distribution of gifts. Thinking, 'Therefore we shall don the armor of generosity and set about our task with diligence, and in this way we shall carry them across the ocean of birth on the ship of generosity,' those bodhisattva mahāsattvas, through the meritorious deed of fully practicing what arises from generosity, lead them from entry into the unsurpassed ocean of the Buddha's wisdom all the way to full attainment of empowerment as unsurpassed kings of Dharma.

"Venerable Blessed One, here there are sentient beings who hold that things are permanent, who are without wealth and ample enjoyments, and who suffer and are worn down by their seeking. Since they cannot be brought to maturity without the distribution of moral discipline, those bodhisattva mahāsattvas give rise to great compassion for these eternalists here. Thinking, 'On the ship of those who have donned the armor of moral discipline, we shall carry these eternalists across this ocean of birth,' those bodhisattva mahāsattvas, through the meritorious deed of fully practicing what arises from moral discipline, bring sentient beings to maturity by the path of the ten virtuous actions, and lead them from entry into the unsurpassed ocean of the Buddha's wisdom all the way to full attainment of empowerment as unsurpassed kings of Dharma.

"Venerable Blessed One, here there are sentient beings whose minds are given over to slander, harsh speech, covetousness and malice. They hold the view of the perishable collection as a self, they are without wealth and enjoyments, and they suffer and are worn down by their seeking. Since those beings cannot be brought to maturity without the moral discipline and vow of going forth, those bodhisattva mahāsattvas give rise to great compassion for those frivolous beings who are given over to slander, harsh speech, covetousness and malice, and who hold the view of the perishable collection. They think, 'Blessed One, we shall cause those beings to enter the teaching by way of impermanence, and we shall bring beings to maturity through the vow of going forth. Having set about it with patience and diligence, we shall carry

them across the ocean of birth on the ship of the vow of going forth.' Through the meritorious deed that arises from moral discipline, those bodhisattva mahāsattvas constantly bring sentient beings to maturity through the moral discipline and vow of going forth. In this way those bodhisattva mahāsattvas lead them from entry into the unsurpassed ocean of the Buddha's wisdom all the way to attainment of empowerment as unsurpassed kings of Dharma.

"Blessed One, when the bodhisattva mahāsattvas purify and train in the perfection of the first meditative concentration, how do they seek out the limbs of meditative concentration, pass completely beyond the desire realm, come to possess the five limbs and abandon the five, and seek to sport by means of the four bases of miraculous power? How do they become skilled at going with the speed of lightning to all buddhafields in order to make offerings and pay homage to all those buddhas, the blessed ones, and to hear the sublime Dharma? How do they dry up the three paths of sentient beings, namely the path of karma, the path of affliction and the path of suffering, and how do they bring to completion the meritorious deeds that arise from meditation? Likewise, how do they bring the perfection of meditative concentration to completion? How do their six perfections become complete, and how do they swiftly and fully awaken into unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening?"

The Blessed One said, "Śrī, Knower of Rites, excellent, excellent!

Śrī, Knower of Rites, though you have fully practiced these four dharmas and made yourself familiar with them, you think to ask the Tathāgata about this matter for the sake of other beings and other persons. Therefore, Śrī, Knower of Rites, listen well and keep it firmly in mind, and I shall explain."

So it runs, from "Venerable Blessed One, I shall do just that," up to "The Blessed One spoke these words."

"Śrī, Knower of Rites, you ask how it is that bodhisattva mahāsattvas, when they purify and train in the perfection of the first meditative concentration, come to know the limbs of meditative concentration, pass completely beyond the desire realm, come to possess the five limbs and abandon the five, directly know how to sport by means of the four bases of miraculous power, become skilled at going with the speed of lightning to all buddhafields in order to make offerings and pay homage to all those buddhas, the blessed ones, and to hear the sublime Dharma, dry up the three paths of sentient beings, namely the path of karma, the path of affliction and the path of suffering, bring to

completion the meritorious deeds that arise from meditation, bring the perfection of meditative concentration to completion, have their six perfections become complete, and swiftly and fully awaken into unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

"Śrī, Knower of Rites, here, first of all, bodhisattva mahāsattvas direct the mind to all the objects that are the signs of breathing in and breathing out. With an undistracted mind they breathe in, and they breathe out. What a bodhisattva picks out with the mind of the first in-breath is his conceptual thought. What he picks out with the mind of the out-breath, as the breath goes forth, is his analysis. Through the delight and satisfaction in this, through one-pointedness of mind and through undistractedness, he abides in that going forth and has a mind that abandons conceptual thought and analysis. In this way he attains the first meditative concentration, which is accompanied by conceptual thought and analysis.

"At that point these signs arise: his whole body trembles, and it grows warm. There he abandons the obscuration of sensual desire, and he suppresses all unwholesome dharmas. When he abides attending with intense effort, his conceptual thought and analysis are stilled, and so he attains the second meditative concentration, which is without conceptual thought and analysis. Then his whole body becomes deeply soothed, blissful and satisfied, just as one feels bliss when lukewarm milk is poured over the body all at once. He knows, 'I have become like this,' and he knows, 'I possess such delight and bliss, free of material things.'

"Having gained faith in the Three Jewels, that bodhisattva thinks, 'Having donned the great armor for the sake of all beings, I shall exert myself in meditative concentration as well, and by every means I shall give up even the bliss of body and mind.' That bodhisattva mahāsattva lets go of the mental objects used to become familiar with breathing in and breathing out. He directs his mind to the tip of the nose, and with a mind that abides in the in-breath and the out-breath, by which the breath enters and goes forth, he examines closely. He examines the momentary disintegration, arising and perishing of that mind, and he realizes that mind, mentation and consciousness, and all the aggregates, elements and sense sources, are like the moon in water, like an optical illusion, like a mirage and like lightning, that they are without an owner, and that all of them are subject to momentary perishing. In this way he utterly lets go of delight and bliss, and so he attains the third meditative concentration as well.

"When, as those dharmas increase, he abides having completed the fourth meditative concentration with a mind that attends to cessation, these signs arise: even with both eyes closed, he sees appearances like the great light of the sun. Then he thinks, 'Since, on the condition of the appearance of the power of signs, the aggregates, elements and sense sources, the afflictions and the secondary afflictions of all beings increase and blaze, I shall by every means give up the appearances that are objects of the attending mind.'

"Then, by way of their arising, perishing and cessation, he completely stills his feeling, perception, volition and contact, which are the origins of attention, and he enters the utterly pure city of cessation. He abides in the thorough pliancy of body, speech and mental attention. And he also rises from that state.

"Or else he takes up the signs of breathing in and breathing out, and by attending to contact he examines the signs closely. Again, he enters the samādhi of emptiness. Or else he correctly views the objects that are the signs of the arising and perishing of the in-breath and the out-breath; he abides in that samādhi of aspiration as well. Or else he correctly views the stilling and cessation of the in-breath and the out-breath; he abides in the signless samādhi. In the same way his cultivation of the four applications of mindfulness becomes complete, and with it his cultivation of the three gateways to liberation becomes complete as well.

"Or else, without disparaging the in-breath and the out-breath, he examines them closely through an object taken in the manner of perishing. With that, his cultivation of the four right abandonments becomes complete as well. Or else he examines closely the signs of the arising and setting of the in-breath and the out-breath.

With that, his cultivation of the four bases of miraculous power becomes complete as well. Or else, focusing on the signs of the in-breath and the out-breath, he examines his own body closely as crumbling into powder, like motes of dust in the sun's rays. With that, his cultivation of the five faculties becomes complete as well. Or else he examines the three formations closely by way of the arising and setting of the in-breath and the out-breath. With that, his cultivation of the five powers becomes complete as well. Or else, by way of making clear the signs of the feeling of the in-breath and the out-breath, he examines the aggregates closely as stilled and fully stilled. In the same way, his cultivation of the seven limbs of awakening becomes complete as well. Or else, by attending to the yoga of the wind of the in-breath

and the out-breath, he crumbles to dust and scatters everything that appears as form in the earth element, and he fully attains the samādhis that are signless, without remainder, inexpressible, without characteristics and without cognition, in which the three formations are stilled, fully stilled and ceased, and which are without an object.

"Such a samādhi of sporting in meditative concentration is the purification of the perfection of meditative concentration that bodhisattva mahāsattvas share in common, and the purification of the perfection of meditative concentration is also shared in common by all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Some who abide in it abide in the fruit of stream-entry. Some of weak diligence grow in the qualities of the śrāvakas, and some go as far as abiding in the fruit of arhatship.

"But those bodhisattva mahāsattvas who possess great compassion, whose effort is steadfast, who look to all beings, and who have made themselves familiar with immeasurable accumulations of merit and wisdom, abide in that yoga of the samādhi of sporting through the purification of meditative concentration, and yet they neither turn back nor enter the certainty of the śrāvakas. Those bodhisattva mahāsattvas don the great armor, and they go from abiding in the purification of the perfection of meditative concentration and of the application to the discriminating knowledges, all the way to bringing the perfection of meditative concentration to completion and having their six perfections become complete.

"Śrī, Knower of Rites, in any realm where monks, nuns, laymen and laywomen, and sons and daughters of good family who have truly entered the Śrāvaka Vehicle, the Pratyekabuddha Vehicle or the Great Vehicle, abide with such attention of sporting through the purification of meditative concentration, that realm will be well protected by all the lords of the gods. That realm will be well protected by all the lords of the nāgas, the lords of the yakṣas, the lords of the asuras, the lords of the garuḍas, the lords of the kiṃnaras, the lords of the mahoragas, the lords of the pretas and the lords of the piśācas, for as long as worthy recipients of offerings who possess such samādhis are settled there.

"The king of that realm, too, will obtain ten pleasing things. What are the ten? Freedom from illness, the complete stilling of all illness, long life, a fine form, a fine complexion, lovely limbs and features, a retinue of good people, the practice of well-performed conduct, application to loving-kindness and compassion, and fair renown. That realm which has worthy recipients of

offerings who possess such samādhis, a realm bound for the higher states, will flourish with those ten qualities and great benefits.

"It will not be harmed by its own armies or the armies of others, by bandits and thieves, by savage men, wild beasts or tigers, by bees, gadflies or moths, by excessive rain or excessive drought, by untimely winds, by hail, by scorching sun or by burning heat. The ground of that realm is level, without wildernesses or ravines. There is neither scorching heat nor snow. Various seeds flourish there. Grain, medicines, grasses, trees, fruit trees and water are abundant and never go to waste. There flowers, medicines, grains and flavors are abundant and are not wasted. In that realm there arise no unpleasant sounds, no external enemies, no armies of internal strife, no famines, no diseases, no untimely diseases and no deaths.

"The beings there are long-lived and of good complexion. They have much happiness, and their minds are untroubled. They are endowed with play and delight, and they are inclined toward the practice of Dharma and toward the higher states. In that realm the worthy recipients of offerings dwell with delight, in harmony with attention to yoga. There is no lack of food and drink and of enjoyments. It is made stable by pleasing great elements. The faculties and elements flourish and nothing is out of harmony. The people in that realm are brave and mindful, possess loving-kindness and compassion, and are inclined toward the higher states. Śrī, Knower of Rites, that realm is well adorned with those ten things.

"Śrī, Knower of Rites, the karmic obscuration of bodhisattvas is this: to forsake the Great Vehicle, and to deceive others and set them on the level of the śrāvakas. For the sake of bringing all beings to maturity, such is the perfection of sporting in the meditative concentration and samādhi of the śrāvakas. Those śrāvakas who do not know the limbs of meditative concentration in their completeness have not abandoned the five limbs of the prison house of the three realms, and they possess the five limbs.

"Those who have completely passed beyond the three realms, who are firmly established on the level of no more learning, who as meditators sport in the eight liberations, who have attained the perfection of the superknowledges, who go forth over eons, who are born from the mouths of all the buddhas, the blessed ones, and who possess the Dharma and are emanations of the Dharma, are nevertheless unable to go to other buddhafields to make offerings and pay homage to the buddhas, the blessed ones, and to hear the

Dharma, and they are unable to dry up the three paths of other beings and other persons. Where the superknowledges of śrāvakas who sport in meditative concentration are like that, the qualities and benefits of that realm are just as was stated before."

Here ends the first chapter, illustrating the śrāvakas, from the Essence of the Mountain chapter of the fifteenth Great Vehicle sūtra of the Great Assembly.

"Śrī, Knower of Rites, you may ask how the purification of the perfection of meditative concentration is set forth as common to bodhisattva mahāsattvas and to all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, and by what means bodhisattva mahāsattvas bring the remaining five perfections to completion.

"Śrī, Knower of Rites, in every in-breath and out-breath these bodhisattva mahāsattvas examine the arising and perishing of the five aggregates of clinging. In this way they dry up craving and attachment, and yet they do not enter the fixed certainty. They also directly know how to sport by means of the four bases of miraculous power. They are also skilled at going with the speed of lightning to all buddhafields in order to make offerings and pay homage to all those buddhas, the blessed ones, and to hear the sublime Dharma. They dry up the three paths of sentient beings, the path of karma, the path of affliction and the path of suffering. They pass completely beyond the desire realm, and yet they do not forsake the desire realm. In order to bring all beings to maturity, they display birth in the places of the various destinies, and yet they are not stained by the faults of the womb. They cut through the net of the afflictions of beings, and yet they do not apprehend beings.

"Śrī, Knower of Rites, here bodhisattva mahāsattvas examine the in-breath and the out-breath, which differ from each other, just as they are, and yet they do not cognize them moment by moment. They thoroughly know, just as they are, the aggregate of clinging that is the form of the in-breath and the out-breath, and likewise feeling, perception and formations, and likewise the aggregate of clinging that is the consciousness of the in-breath and the out-breath. The in-breath is one thing, and the out-breath is another. The discernment of the in-breath is one thing, and the discernment of the out-breath is another. The feeling, perception and volitional attention of the in-breath are one thing, and the feeling, perception and volitional attention of the out-breath are another. The volition of the in-breath is one thing, and that of the out-breath is another. When one discerns the in-breath, at that time one does not discern the out-breath. When one discerns the out-breath, at that

time one does not discern the in-breath.

"Feeling, perception and volitional attention in the three-segmented wheel of saṃsāra are just like this: by the cause of their engagement, beings are driven without interruption into the ocean of birth and are not set free. Again and again they are born, they age, they die, and they are born once more. Because he has fully awakened to these dharmas, he thoroughly knows, just as it is, the escape from aging and death. Those beings do not examine the in-breath and the out-breath just as they are.

"In this way the in-breath and the out-breath enter and go out through the doors of the ocean of existence. Likewise, although the in-breath and the out-breath enter and go out through all the pore openings, some ninety-nine hundred thousand niyutas of them, those ninety-nine hundred thousand niyutas of pore openings appear neither to diminish nor to increase. No prior limit or later limit appears, and no beginning, middle or end. Neither entering nor going out appears.

"He thinks, 'By every means I shall abide with diligence in the characteristic of arising and perishing, by way of the arising and perishing of the in-breath and the out-breath of all the pores.' That bodhisattva mahāsattva applies himself to the arising and perishing of the in-breath and the out-breath of the nine doors of the wounds, and examines each of them individually. Likewise he abides with diligence in the characteristic of the arising and perishing of the in-breath and the out-breath of each pore of all those pore openings, some ninety-nine hundred thousand niyutas of them.

"Or else, if he imagines a pore opening to be as small as the tip of a hair, he sees the in-breath and the out-breath moving there as small as well. Or if he imagines it to be large, he sees it correspondingly as large as a big mustard seed. Or if he imagines it to be the size of an emblic myrobalan, he sees it as the size of an emblic myrobalan. Or if he imagines each and every pore to be the size of a bilva fruit, he sees it as the size of a bilva fruit. Or if he imagines it to be a thousand yojanas in size, he sees it as a thousand yojanas in size. Or if he imagines it to be the size of a single four-continent world, he sees it as the size of a single four-continent world. Or if he imagines each pore to be vast, he sees it correspondingly as vast. The same is to be applied to the measure of the eye as well.

Where sentient beings bound up with old age and death, driven without interruption along the river of saṃsāra, undergo suffering of many different

kinds, he thinks, "By all means I must cast off perceptions of form in every respect," and he applies his mind to the wind element. Because he abandons perceptions of form in every respect, he attains the inexpressible meditative absorption, which is not the domain of any śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas.

In it the earth element is not apprehended. The water element is not apprehended. The fire element is not apprehended. The wind element is not apprehended. The space element is not apprehended. The consciousness element is not apprehended. The movement of the aggregates, elements and sense sources is not apprehended. The prior extreme is not apprehended. The later extreme is not apprehended. This world is not apprehended. The world beyond is not apprehended. The fruit, the karmic maturation, of actions well done and badly done is not apprehended. Arising is not apprehended. Perishing is not apprehended. Affliction is not apprehended. Purification is not apprehended. That bodhisattva great being abides by means of those abodes of peace.

If he wishes to sustain, through this meditative absorption of the inexpressible emptiness of all phenomena, for immeasurable eons, he sustains it accordingly through the power of meditative absorption. If he wishes to remain for immeasurable eons in this meditative absorption of the inexpressible emptiness of all phenomena, he remains accordingly. In this way, in order to bring sentient beings to maturity, he completes the six perfections, just like the bodhisattva great being Kṣitigarbha.

Śrī, Knower of Rites, when a bodhisattva great being who has gained mastery of the perfection of the meditative absorption of the inexpressible emptiness of all phenomena wishes to enter this meditative absorption, then, first of all, in order to bring sentient beings to maturity, through the power of merit and wisdom he makes an aspiration such as this: "For as long as I have not arisen from meditative absorption, may the sentient beings of this very land, of this very four-continent world, and so on up to the sentient beings of this very buddhafield, be endowed in abundance with enjoyments, with things to use, and with requisites of every kind. That is, there may whatever pleasing dwellings, bodies, bodily shapes and complexions, limbs and minor limbs, ornaments, flowing garments, pendant hangings, garlands, bedding, clothing, food, drink, forms, sounds, smells, tastes and textures the sentient beings desire, in whatever manner they desire them, and in whatever quantity they desire, come to be." Having made this aspiration, that bodhisattva great being then enters that meditative absorption. For as long as the bodhisattva great

being who has entered meditative absorption remains in that attainment, such enjoyments and requisites arise there for the sentient beings, just as was described above.

Furthermore, that bodhisattva great being makes an aspiration such as this: "For as long as I possess such a meditative absorption, within the bounds I have set, may the bodily illnesses of sentient beings, those arising from wind, those arising from bile, those arising from phlegm and those arising from their combination, and likewise the illnesses of the mind, attachment, aversion, delusion and the rest, be fully pacified. May the illnesses that come from harm by humans and nonhumans be fully pacified. May they abide in the ten courses of virtuous action." Having made this aspiration, he then enters meditative absorption. And so, for as long as that bodhisattva great being possesses such a meditative absorption, he fully pacifies such illnesses, the sufferings of body and mind, of the sentient beings within the bounds he has set.

Furthermore, that bodhisattva great being makes an aspiration such as this: "For as long as I remain endowed with such a meditative absorption, may the sufferings of the hell beings, of the animals and of those in the world of Yama, lord of death, be fully pacified: hunger, thirst, heat and cold, meeting with what is unpleasant, separation from what is dear, the suffering of weariness and the suffering of searching. For as long as I am endowed with such a meditative absorption, may sentient beings be endowed with diligence. May those who are devoid of all virtuous qualities strive in all virtuous qualities. For as long as I am endowed with such a meditative absorption, may sentient beings be endowed with a mind of loving-kindness toward other sentient beings, a mind of benefit, an undisturbed mind, a mind without resentment, an untroubled mind, a mind of compassion, a mind of tender affection, a mind of meditative concentration, a mind that abides skilled in the meditative attainments, and a mind free from confusion. For as long as I am endowed with such a meditative absorption, may the darkness of delusion of sentient beings, and their views of permanence and annihilation, be fully pacified. May their clinging to views be fully pacified at all times. For as long as I am endowed with such a meditative absorption, may sentient beings set their minds on the Three Jewels and show them respect and reverence. May they be free of the four inversions and be endowed with a mind that abides in the aspects of the Four Noble Truths. May they be endowed with a mind that abides fully in the noble ultimate truth."

When that bodhisattva great being wishes to enter meditative absorption in order to bring sentient beings to maturity, then through wisdom, through the power of merit and through the power of skillful means, he blesses things in this way: "For as long as I have not arisen from meditative absorption," he blesses the sentient beings of this very land, of this very four-continent world, and so on up to the sentient beings of this very buddhafield, within whatever bounds he has set, so that they are brought to happiness in this way. After that, he enters such a meditative absorption of the inexpressible emptiness of all phenomena. As soon as that bodhisattva great being has entered the attainment, he brings to maturity the sentient beings within the bounds he has set, through such various qualities that, by the power of the bodhisattva's meditative absorption, bring them happiness; and for that long the bodhisattva great beings do not arise from the meditative absorption of the inexpressible emptiness of all phenomena.

While that bodhisattva great being is thus absorbed in the attainment, no harm or change befalls his body. No harm from hunger and thirst befalls him. No harm from fire befalls him: he is not burned by the fire at the end of the eon, nor even by ordinary fire. He is not carried off by water. He is not consumed by an eon of disease. He is not consumed by an eon in which the land has become a wilderness of famine. Except when he deliberately relinquishes the formative force of life, his formative force of life and his faculty of vitality are not exhausted. Neither his body nor his life is harmed by humans, by nonhumans, by wind, or by the scorching of the sun. Such is his absorption in the attainment.

Even after arising from that meditative absorption, if he wishes, he can place immeasurable buddhafields inside the tip of a single hair. If he wishes, he can also behold inside the nail of a single finger all the buddhas, the blessed ones, with their retinues, and all the bodhisattva great beings with their retinues, gathered together without exception. If he wishes, he can also place all immeasurable sentient beings inside the tip of a single hair, and there he sees the respective lands and spheres of activity of each and every sentient being as spacious. If he wishes, he places the entire wind element of endless, boundless buddhafields inside the tip of a single hair, and there he moves about as in the open expanse of space; yet it neither appears larger nor appears smaller. If he wishes, that bodhisattva great being places the entire water element of all buddhafields inside a single pea, and there he moves about as in the open expanse of space; yet it neither appears larger nor

appears smaller.

Except through the power of his own aspiration, that bodhisattva is not born again and again in a womb. He is not born in the lower realms. He does not become a woman. He does not obtain a lowly birth. His limbs are not impaired. He is not confused in the conduct of body, speech and mind. Except through the power of his own aspiration for the sake of bringing sentient beings to maturity, he is not born in empty buddhafields. He is never parted from seeing the buddhas, hearing the Dharma, and honoring the Saṅgha. Through wisdom, merit, meditative absorption and skill in means he brings sentient beings to maturity, and until his unsurpassed complete nirvāṇa he is never parted from fearlessness.

Śrī, Knower of Rites, the bodhisattva great being, having donned such great armor, while purifying and training in the perfection of the first meditative concentration, fully transcends the desire realm. Likewise he also comes to know the factors of meditative concentration: he is endowed with five factors and has abandoned five factors. Likewise, he has the higher knowledges and plays with the four bases of miraculous power. In order to make offerings to and honor all those buddhas, the blessed ones, and to hear the true Dharma, he is skilled in going to all buddhafields with the speed of lightning.

It is by this that he dries up the three paths of all sentient beings: the path of karma, the path of affliction and the path of suffering. Because he dries them up in this way, the bodhisattva completes the perfection of meditative concentration. Likewise his six perfections become complete, and he will swiftly awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

Moreover, when the Blessed One had taught the completion of the perfection of meditative concentration, the fifty thousand sentient beings in that assembly who had previously cultivated these four qualities attained acceptance of the nonarising of phenomena. There eighty-four thousand living beings attained the meditative absorption of heroic progress (śūraṃgama). There ninety-nine thousand times a hundred billion living beings attained the completion of the perfection of meditative concentration. There countless hundreds of thousands of hundred billions of sentient beings who had not previously generated the mind set on awakening generated the mind set on unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, and became irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

From the fifteenth sūtra of the Great Assembly, a Great Vehicle sūtra, the chapter of the Essence of the Mountain, the second section, the Illustration of Meditative Concentration, is complete.

Then, in that very place, the bodhisattva great being Kṣitigarbha spoke these words to the great goddess Śrī: "Śrī, Knower of Rites, this great four-continent world is to be greatly honored for a long time by all those bodhisattva great beings, to be protected, to be kept in mind, and it is worthy of homage. See how the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Śākyamuni has now gathered such great assemblies of all those bodhisattva great beings, has led them to enter the entire path of awakening, to go to the far shore of skill in means of the irreversible wheel, and has proclaimed the ground of empowerment as a buddha. You have completed the irreversible wheel and, devoted to the perfection of generosity, you have provided food and drink to such worthy recipients of gifts. Through that diligence of yours, will you swiftly complete the six perfections? Will you abide in the wisdom of omniscience?"

To this the great goddess Śrī replied: "It is just as the great and holy being has said. Long ago, countless eons in the past, when the bodhisattva Śākyamuni was practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, he and I made a pledge to one another: 'When you awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, may I then attain the state of the great goddess Śrī in that great four-continent world.' And I undertook that there I would give to sentient beings all provisions of food and drink.

"Son of noble family, listen to me. Long ago, countless eons in the past, at that time there appeared a tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly and completely awakened buddha called Indraketudhvajarāja. The lifespan of beings was a thousand years, and so on, up to: At that time there was a layman called Stainless Star Glory, who was disciplined, clear-minded, fearless and very learned, who taught the Dharma to the four assemblies, and who had a great retinue, an excellent retinue. His eldest son, called Vimalaśrī, spoke to his father in verse:

'Father, why, even giving up your own body and life,
Do you strive and exert yourself with an undaunted mind?
Father, why, not passing into nirvāṇa in this life,
Do you so diligently give beings the highest protection?'

He answered his son Vimalaśrī in verse:

'Beings are bewildered by the sufferings of saṃsāra;
They have entered bad paths, ablaze with the fire of afflictions.
Seeing them ever tormented by sufferings,
I strive in order to quench the fires of affliction.
Those whose wisdom has decayed, who have gone beyond all bounds,
Who have fallen far from the path and go to the lower realms,
Who have fallen into the unbearable river of saṃsāra:
To deliver them I, too, engage in this conduct.
Those who have utterly abandoned generosity, discipline and restraint,
Who have always fallen from the happiness of gods and humans,
Who are always parted from spiritual friends:
For them I shall become one who shows the path.
Beings ever bound in the prison of afflictions,
Without protector, their eyes destroyed,
Attached to bad views, eating flesh and blood:
To purify them, I engage in this conduct.
Enduring the Avīci hell for the sake of each sentient being,
Such compassion I shall generate for beings.
So that each and every one of those beings may be freed,
I shall take on unbearable, hard-to-endure suffering.
My son, I shall practice the supreme conduct of awakening.
I shall not seek the knowledge of the śrāvakas,
Nor shall I seek the knowledge of the pratyekabuddhas;
I shall seek unsurpassed wisdom.
As long as many beings, numerous as the sands of the Ganges,
Have not been freed from their sufferings,
So long I shall not awaken here to the supreme awakening;
Only afterward shall I touch that supreme awakening.
My son, having generated such compassion
Equally toward all beings,
Dedicate the virtues with which you are ever endowed
To the supreme and noble awakening.
To free beings completely from the fire of afflictions,
Take on unbearable, hard-to-endure sufferings.
Practice well generosity, discipline and restraint;
That you will become a perfect buddha there is no doubt.
At the time when I have not yet attained supreme awakening,
At that time you will become a giver to beings.

Having prophesied your supreme awakening,
I abide well and firmly in this pledge.'"

"Son of noble family, at that time I made this pledge in the presence of the Tathāgata Indraketudhvajarāja: 'For as long as I wander in saṃsāra, I shall train myself in observances, austerities, hardships, generosity, discipline, restraint, meditative concentration, learning, giving away, and service of many kinds. I shall train myself in hardships and in relinquishing of every kind. When, in the age when beings live for a hundred years, in those fields thoroughly bewildered by afflictions and the turbidity of afflictions, there is a field in which a buddha will fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, in that field I too shall manifest as the unsurpassed lord of the state of Śrī. In his teaching I shall become the unsurpassed giver of provisions of food and drink. There I shall serve the Tathāgata Śākyamuni and his retinue with foods and drinks of many kinds. There I shall receive, directly from the Tathāgata Śākyamuni, the prophecy of my unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. There will appear there sentient beings who are savage, harsh, without tenderness, ungrateful, unjust, of dreadful conduct and evil-minded; they will send down untimely hailstorms, heat, cold and torrential rains, and so spoil the grain, fruit, crops, medicines, trees and flavors of sentient beings, rob them of their vitality, waste the enjoyments and the things that sentient beings use, and plunge everything into darkness. All of these I shall turn back by the might of merit and the power of wisdom. I shall bring them to faith.'"

The second fascicle.

"When those sentient beings are deprived of enjoyments and things to use, they engage in the ten nonvirtues. They utterly fall away from the qualities of the ten virtues. In this way those to be trained by the Blessed One there, lacking the teaching, the lineage of the Three Jewels and the requisites, will become without renown. Therefore, there, by means of the causes of abundant enjoyments and requisites for use, I shall bring sentient beings to maturity for unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.'

"When I had made this aspiration before the Blessed One, so that in the future I would fulfill my intention in this way, that Blessed One then gave his approval, saying 'Excellent!' Because I had then fulfilled my intention just as I had aspired, the Tathāgata Indraketudhvajarāja gave his approval, saying, 'Excellent, excellent, son of noble family, that you have made such an

aspiration! Son of noble family, I shall give you the dhāraṇī called the Prosperity-Bringing Essence of the Water Mansion. Will you be able, with this essence of dhāraṇī, to bring sentient beings fully to maturity in this way? By endowing immeasurable sentient beings with abundant enjoyments and requisites for use, you will deliver them from the river of afflictions.

tadyathā jalambha mahājalambha anujalambha sarbajalambha ogajalambha yakṣabrijalambha nāgabrijalambha ugarabrijalambha hastibrijalambha ajalambha jalambha manḍūkabrijalambha khamubrijalambha padkabrijalambha amabrijalambha sūcimukhabrijalambha bamra bamra jalabamra bijabhanda prattrapuṣpaphalambha mukṣanribhanas dharma yajñā briṣṭiso hrilambha śaśastudala guṅ guṅ saragunci duṅ guṅ barajabai svāhā

This is the dhāraṇī called the Prosperity-Bringing Essence of the Water Mansion. Will you be able, with this essence of dhāraṇī, to bring sentient beings fully to maturity in this way?'

"Son of noble family, there I received this dhāraṇī called the Prosperity-Bringing Essence of the Water Mansion from the Tathāgata Indraketudhvajarāja. Having received it, I made these various offerings and services to that tathāgata, and I also practiced moral discipline, learning and observances. After that, I made such aspirations before as many as ten thousand buddhas, and because of that I have now, in this Fortunate Eon, attained the state of the Great Śrī.

"If you ask why I do not sleep while I now accomplish such a great purpose here, it is because, since that time, many wrathful nāgas have appeared, and many savage, harsh, faithless yakṣas, rākṣasas, asuras, kumbhāṇḍas, pretas and piśācas, given to pitilessness and lack of tenderness, have come. They harm those who are living beings, and in their dreadful conduct they send down untimely winds, torrential rains, great droughts and violent hail, and bring forth heat and cold. They send foreign enemies, internal strife, ruin, harm from hostile armies, quarrels, the scorching of the sun and gales. They have not been blessed by the Victors of the past, and since they have no regard for the world beyond, they show no reverence for this dhāraṇī called the Prosperity-Bringing Essence of the Water Mansion. They spoil, destroy and rob of vitality the seeds, sprouts, leaves, flowers, fruits, flavors, grains, medicines, enjoyments and things used by sentient beings. They breathe upon the essences of the earth, and so make the essences of the earth faulty, polluted, diseased, choked with clods, coarse, tasteless, hard and

foul-smelling; and so they bring no delight to sentient beings."

"The sentient beings who depend on these essences of the earth make use of the seeds, stalks, leaves, flowers, fruits, flavors, grains, medicines, enjoyments and things for use, and so their minds have no regard for the world beyond, and toward sentient beings they have taken on minds that are harsh, resentful, malicious, hostile, without compassion and without tenderness. They are tormented by various illnesses, ugly in form and coarse in body, afflicted and inwardly degraded; they have entered into bad views and rely on bad refuges. They, and so on down to the wild animals and birds, have not gained minds of faith, clarity and joy toward the Three Jewels, nor minds that hold them as supreme and show them respect and reverence. Seized by various illnesses and by bad views, and falling in with the deceitful, they act with confusion of body, speech and mind toward the Three Jewels. Those who are evil-minded, whose discipline is corrupt and who practice what is not restraint are shunned by the monks who are endowed with discipline, rich in good qualities and possessed of unimpeded eloquence.

"Now, here, sentient beings abuse, revile, disparage, plunder, bring to ruin, despise, deceive and threaten, and act disgracefully; they have abandoned conscience and shame, they have minds that delight in the ten courses of nonvirtuous action, they have minds that have abandoned the practice of all virtue, they are devoid of merit and wisdom, short-lived, and go to the lower realms. Therefore all these sentient beings cannot be satisfied even with all enjoyments and things for use, nor can they be brought to maturity.

"Now, holy being, you know the qualities of all the buddhas without exception and are wise. You have gone to the far shore of skill in the practice of every meditative absorption, dhāraṇī and acceptance. Adorned with compassion and tenderness, a great sage who has gone to the far shore of knowledge, you have become the supreme banner among all the hosts of bodhisattvas and bring all sentient beings to maturity. So now generate compassion and tenderness for this four-continent world. Consider with your understanding how, in this four-continent world, the wrathful nāgas can be turned back, and how the wrathful yakṣas, rākṣasas, asuras, kumbhāṇḍas, pretas, piśācas and pūtanas can be turned back; and how by every means they may send down rain and bring forth water in due season, bring about abundant harvests, and apply heat and cold in their proper seasons. On that basis the enjoyments and things used by sentient beings will not decline, and all the essences of the earth will be without fault, without disease, full of nourishment, causes and

conditions of mindfulness, delicious, fragrant and of excellent taste. The sentient beings who depend on these essences of the earth and enjoy those enjoyments and things for use will be free of illness, endowed with mindfulness, and so on, as was stated before."

Then the bodhisattva great being Kṣitigarbha spoke these words to the great goddess Śrī: "Śrī, Knower of Rites, I could transform all the great elements of this entire buddhafield, without exception, into divine bliss, and so let sentient beings here enjoy them for as long as a hundred thousand eons; yet the sentient beings here would not be able to enjoy them. Why is that? These sentient beings are devoid of merit and are not vessels for enjoying vast enjoyments and things for use. I could transform this entire Sahā buddhafield into vast divine palaces, adorned with divine dwellings and couches, ornaments, clothing, flowing garments, incense, flowers, garlands, fruits, trees, the sound of music, cymbals, songs and jewels of every kind; yet the sentient beings here, being devoid of merit and so not having become vessels, would not be able to enjoy them. Only the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas, the bodhisattva great beings of the tenth ground, and those who have gained mastery of the meditative absorption of heroic progress can make use of such things.

"If I am able to place the entire realm of sentient beings, without exception, in absorption in the four meditative concentrations, what need is there even to mention pacifying the wrathful nāgas here, and so on up to the wrathful pūtanas? But it would not be proper for me to display the domains of miraculous power without the Tathāgata's permission. It is like this: it is impossible for the precious minister and the precious householder to array the fourfold army without the permission of the universal monarch. Why is that? All the bodhisattva great beings, without exception, are children of the Tathāgata, born of his heart, born of his speech, arisen from the Dharma and emanated by the Dharma. Therefore no one at all is able to display the domains of miraculous power without the Tathāgata's permission."

"Śrī, Knower of Rites, there are, however, the vidyā-mantras of the dhāraṇī collection called the Jewel Palace of the Rivers, the condensed words of secret mantra, and the miraculous displays brought about by the blessing of the lineage of the Three Jewels of all the buddhas, the blessed ones of the three times. Śrī, Knower of Rites, now put your request to the Tathāgata, and the Tathāgata will now teach you the vidyā-mantras of the dhāraṇī collection called the Jewel Palace of the Rivers and the condensed words of secret

mantra. I too rejoice in it. And you, fulfill all your intentions!"

Then the great goddess Śrī, the great goddess Sarasvatī, the great goddess Dṛḍhā, the great goddess Light-Maker, the great goddess Splendid One, the great goddess Virtuous One, the great goddess Tamālagarbhā, the great goddess Sun-Self, and the great goddess Crystal One, surrounded and preceded by some eighty hundred thousand times ten quadrillion other deities, rose from their seats. They bowed with joined palms toward where the Blessed One was, and the great goddess Śrī then made her request in verse:

You whose conduct is utterly pure, stainless of every stain,
Please teach, like the sun, what clears away the turbid murk of the afflictions.
Since we thirst for the dhāraṇī of the rivers,
Sugata, please teach the dhāraṇī collection that brings pacification.
The vidyā-mantra of the rivers, the supreme and excellent words of secret mantra,
Precious Sage, please teach them.
Then the turbid rivers will become clear,
And the essences of the earth will henceforth no longer be in want of water.
Pacifying untimely winds, the scorching of the sun,
Dust, and great and terrible drought,
So that no one robs the crops and fruits of their vigor,
Please teach what will protect them.
Then, free of illness and endowed with mindfulness,
And engaging in what is virtuous,
They will utterly reject the dreadful ones
Who hold wrong views of the Victor's teaching.
Victor, please teach what clears sorrow and affliction from my heart,
What accomplishes radiance,
And that by which I may be able
To bring all sentient beings to full maturity.
These gods who make their supplication in the Sage's presence,
Please set them on the profound path of the Great Vehicle.
You who gather together beings rich in qualities, together with their fruits,
The bodhisattvas of the ten directions proclaim your praise.
So that the rivers flow well and the crops do not fail,
And in order to turn back the evil nāgas, please teach these.

Then the Blessed One said, "Śrī, Knower of Rites, before the assembly the Tathāgata bestows blessing at the proper time. Now, in the midst of the

assembly, the Tathāgata will teach the dhāraṇī called the Prosperity-Bringing Essence of the Water Mansion, blessed by all the buddhas, the blessed ones of the three times. Having heard it, the bodhisattva great beings who have come here from the ten directions will in turn teach this dhāraṇī called the Prosperity-Bringing Essence of the Water Mansion to the sentient beings in those empty buddha fields of the ten directions marked by the five degenerations.

"By the power of the dhāraṇī, untimely winds, the scorching of the sun, cold, heat, torrential rains and great droughts will there be completely pacified. Thereby the gods, yakṣas, rākṣasas, asuras, kumbhāṇḍas, hungry ghosts, piśācas, foul spirits, pūtanas, humans and nonhumans there who pay no heed to the world beyond, and even the wild animals and birds that are savage and fierce, without tenderness toward sentient beings and given over to pitilessness, will become people of faith. Their minds will become gentle. They will become mindful of virtue. They will come to long to seek the Dharma. They will protect the Dharma. They will make the lineage of the Three Jewels blaze.

"Through the might of this dhāraṇī, the sentient beings there will become long-lived. Their complexion will increase. Their crops will increase. Their wealth will increase. Their happiness will increase. Their health will increase. Their renown will increase. Their moral discipline will increase. Their learning will increase. Their generosity will increase. Their loving-kindness will increase. Their compassion will increase. Their wisdom will increase. Their skillful means will increase. Their meditative absorption will increase. Their dhāraṇī will increase. Their discernment of the grounds will increase. Their renunciation will increase. Their bringing of sentient beings to maturity will increase. Their praise of the Great Vehicle will increase in every way. Their special aspirations will increase. Their ascent from ground to ground will increase. Their insight into the aggregates, the elements and the sense sources will increase. Their sense of shame and their conscience will increase. Their grasp of the arrays of qualities of the buddha fields will increase. Their being held always, at every time, in the minds of all the buddhas, the blessed ones of the ten directions, will increase. Their regarding the buddhas, the blessed ones, and the bodhisattva great beings always as spiritual friends will increase. Their play by means of the bases of miraculous power will increase. It completely delivers them from the arising and increase of all afflictions and from the increase of karma. Until they reach unsurpassed nirvāṇa they will not fall away from any virtuous dharmas; they will not fall away entirely."

tadyathā svarabrate nayabrati biṣṭhachati anayabrati śāstārabrati śāraṇabrati kumudabrati sancīrabrati chedasalabrati sarabrate saraparihāre sarabrataparihāre nāyanapratabarihāre bibidhekaparihāre yajñāparihāre binduparihare jalaparihāre kṣetraparihāre dakṣaparihāre sanasaparihūre śrababāṅrai gomayabaṇe madasakhe sunayābhadrajamela bande araṇajūṣe kharabajābhe nārāyaṇabijabhe uraga animiṣe kujarabheme jahanimabhe karmabirale śramasalilai khaḍagaśame asināme agnibhadre naṅgatumpure bāyabe baruṇe kanṭhanibra śakrajñāye anāchebyenṛnaya niletraiyaddha buddha adhiṣṭhite svāhā nārāyaninīlaye svāhā cakrabartakrame svāhā

The very moment the Blessed One had taught this dhāraṇī called the Prosperity-Bringing Essence of the Water Mansion, the great earth shook: the ground of the entire Sahā buddha field shook in six ways. All the assemblies of every kind that had gathered there trembled and quaked; agitated and stricken with dismay, they cried out, "Homage to the Buddha! Homage to the Buddha!"

Then the Blessed One spoke these words to the great goddess Śrī: "Śrī, Knower of Rites, such is the dhāraṇī called the Prosperity-Bringing Essence of the Water Mansion for you. Through its power it completely pacifies all disputes and quarrels. It pacifies all wrathful and savage nāgas. It also pacifies all wrathful and savage yakṣas, humans, nonhumans, and even wild animals and birds. It completely pacifies untimely winds, the scorching of the sun, cold, heat and all great droughts. It makes all crops increase and ripen. It makes sentient beings long-lived. It makes wealth increase. It does all this, up to delivering them from the increase of karma. Until they reach unsurpassed nirvāṇa they will not fall away from any virtuous dharmas; they will not fall away entirely. If anyone listens to, reads or practices this great dhāraṇī, that person will later abide in the Dharma that is free of contradiction and in the three vows."

Then the bodhisattva Kṣitigarbha said, "Venerable Blessed One, here I too shall set forth a great dhāraṇī called Power of Weapons. Through that dhāraṇī called Power of Weapons, all the essences of the earth, which serve for all the enjoyment and use of sentient beings, will not decline; they will not decline at all. No one will be able to steal the vigor of the earth's essences. No one will be able to breathe poisonous breath upon them or to dry them up. No one will be able to make them coarse and tasteless. No one will be able to make them decline or disappear. No one will be able to make crops fail to grow from the soil. No one will be able to make them coarse and tasteless. No one will be

able to steal the vigor of the seeds, sprouts, leaves, flowers, fruits, grains and medicinal plants of the crops. No one will be able to breathe poisonous breath upon them or to dry them up. Nor will anyone be able to make them coarse or tasteless. Nor will anyone be able to rain upon those that have not yet ripened. No one will be able to scorch them with frost and heat or make them unfit to eat. No one will be able, merely by their being eaten, to breathe poisonous breath into the bodies of some beings. No one will be able, on such grounds, to make beings who seek food suffer pains in the belly, or to make their limbs and lesser limbs ache and contract. No one will be able to cause epidemics, forgetfulness, distraction of mind and the loss of mindfulness. No one will be able to cause mutual quarrels and warfare. It joins the minds of sentient beings to those principles, from refraining from taking life and from taking what is not given up to refraining from wrong view; and the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, rākṣasas, kumbhāṇḍas, kiṃnaras, gandharvas, hungry ghosts, piśācas, foul spirits, pūtanas, humans and nonhumans will not be able to do such harm to sentient beings.

tadyathā nābi mahānābi kṣukṣaranābe abiṅgu nābe saṅśoṣaṇa nābe nirājakhabe abaramuni taruṇaruhe narāpadtre jabaprame māsuratre timirapadtre khaṇḍanirahāre cakṣobhase gaṇabime kṣiti tvoye svāhā aṅgurakṣe svāhā puṣpamaye svāhā phalanimabhe svāhā namotoye svāhā śarīranabakramabīṣa svāhā

"Śrī, Knower of Rites, that is the great dhāraṇī called Power of Weapons for you. Through the might of that great dhāraṇī called Power of Weapons, it makes things flourish in this way for sentient beings. It brings about great bliss. For that reason it will swiftly tame sentient beings."

All the assemblies of every kind that had gathered there applauded the bodhisattva great being Kṣitigarbha, saying, "Excellent!" and the Blessed One too granted his approval, saying, "Excellent!": "Excellent, excellent, son of noble family! Son of noble family, you are the elixir of sentient beings, and you have become the physician of sentient beings. In this way you are the grain and the elixir of all the sentient beings of these four continents, and you completely pacify all suffering. You bestow everything that leads to happiness. You are endowed with the arousing of great compassion. You teach so very profound a great dhāraṇī as this one called Power of Weapons. Through that great dhāraṇī, here the vigor of the earth's essences, and the seeds, sprouts, leaves, flowers, flavors, grains and medicinal plants of sentient beings, do not decline but remain flawless, increasing and flourishing.

In the mindstreams of those beings who eat them, it pacifies all the turmoil of strife. Here sentient beings will practice all virtuous dharmas. In these four continents it fully pacifies untimely winds, the scorching of the sun, heat, cold, torrential rains and great droughts, and every disorder of the moon, the sun, the planets, the lunar mansions, day and night, the months, the half-months, the years and the seasons. Through the teaching of that great dhāraṇī, my lineage of the Three Jewels and the way of the Dharma will long endure. Even if, here, benighted and unfortunate outcaste kings and outcaste ministers, swollen with intoxication and arrogance, who have not produced roots of virtue, should harm my teaching, which was thus accomplished with hardship, and my monks, nuns, laymen and laywomen, and so on, up to: for that reason the gods, nāgas and yakṣas will not cause disturbance. Likewise, the arising of everything that conduces to the happiness of sentient beings is as was stated before."

This concludes the third chapter, the Indication of the Complete Pacification of Great Drought, from the chapter of the Essence of the Mountain in the Great Assembly, the fifteenth sūtra of the Great Vehicle.

Then the Blessed One spoke these words to the great goddess Śrī: "Goddess Śrī, Knower of Rites, just as the two of us made pledges to each other long ago in the presence of the Tathāgata Indraketudhvajarāja, so the intentions of us both have been completely fulfilled and accomplished."

Then the great goddess Śrī said, "Venerable Blessed One, so it is. Venerable Sugata, so it is: our intentions have been fulfilled. Just as we pledged to each other long ago in the presence of the Tathāgata Indraketudhvajarāja, our intentions have thus been completely accomplished: you yourself have now appeared in the world as a tathāgata, and I have now attained the state of Śrī. Yet why is it that I am now unable to bring sentient beings to maturity? It is because here the nāgas that are like elephants, the nāgas that are like horses, the nāgas that are like snakes, the nāgas that are like fish and the nāgas that are like frogs are still at their work even at this time. When I teach the profound things that illuminate the world, those nāgas and great nāgas who bring about untimely frost, heat, clouds, mist, storms, torrential rains and great droughts, and who spoil the crops, leaves, flowers, fruits, grains and medicinal plants of sentient beings, have not been driven away.

"Venerable Blessed One, at this present time, in this world system of four continents, there are the nāgas, the great nāgas, the nāga retinues, the males

and females, the boys and girls, all those in these four continents who are born in the nāga womb and who are now present here; the bodhisattva great beings from all the buddha fields of the ten directions who are now present in this great assembly; all the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, rākṣasas, gandharvas, kiṃnaras, asuras, mahoragas, hungry ghosts, piśācas, foul spirits and pūtanas who are now gathered here; the śrāvakas of the Blessed One; and the humans and nonhumans who are now in this great assembly in order to listen to the Dharma. All these sentient beings present before the Blessed One live in dependence on the four kinds of food.

"Venerable Blessed One, at this present time, please pacify the wrathful nāgas who bring ruin. Those wrathful nāgas, having no faith in the word of the Blessed One, are constantly at their work. They are violent toward sentient beings. They spoil the enjoyments and the provisions of sentient beings. They pay no heed to the world beyond. They are without tenderness toward sentient beings and given over to pitilessness, hateful and harsh. Since they create obstacles to my bringing sentient beings to maturity, may the Blessed One please give rise to great compassion for their sake. May the Blessed One please pacify all their wrongdoing."

Then the Blessed One said to the bodhisattva great being, the Essence of the Mountain, who dwells in the abode of the nāgas, "Son of noble family, what kind of aspiration did you make in the presence of the Tathāgata Dīpaṃkara, striving to bring the nāgas to maturity? You made this aspiration: 'By whatever means, I shall be able, in accordance with the Dharma, to remove the poisonous breath of the nāgas, the great nāgas and the wrathful nāgas of the four kinds of birth, of past, present and future times; the poisonous eyes, the poisonous touch and the poisonous tongues of the nāgas; the poison of attachment, the poison of aversion and the poison of delusion; and the evil ways of the wrathful nāgas. By whatever means, I shall make those wrathful nāgas no longer harm the enjoyments and the provisions of sentient beings, or those who are furnished with various necessities. I shall make them gain faith, clarity and joy toward the Three Jewels. I shall make them come to have regard for the world beyond and to be parted from evil ways.'"

When he had said this, the bodhisattva great being, the Essence of the Mountain, said to the Blessed One, "Venerable Blessed One, I shall enter the place where those wrathful nāgas are, and there I shall remain absorbed in the meditative absorption called the Abode of the Haughty Nāgas. Through the power of that meditative absorption, I shall pacify their anger, pride, arrogance

and desire. I shall make them gentle, fit vessels, with pacified minds, with minds that have regard for the world beyond, and with minds of loving-kindness, compassion, tenderness and affection toward all sentient beings. I shall make the wrathful nāgas and the savage nāgas come to faith. I shall make them abide on the ground of a mind that is harmless and tender toward all sentient beings.

"Moreover, those sentient beings who are harmed by storms, torrential rains, great droughts, clouds, great clouds, frost and heat should join their palms, call out my name and say, 'Essence of the Mountain, you of vast compassion, who bring the nāgas to maturity, remember us! Remember us! You who practice for unsurpassed awakening, do you not practice with diligence in the various means and forms of wisdom? Please free us from suffering! Please protect us completely!' Speaking in this way, they should recite this:

tadyathā stambha bhuja bireḍu bhuja goghabirejra bhuja meru bhuja gatuba bhuja hūṃ hūṃ aneba bhuja smara bhuja smara abarta bhuja nimaba bhuja svāhā

"Venerable Blessed One, suppose that sentient beings who have been harmed by the harms that come about because of those wrathful nāgas call out my very name and recite the secret mantra in order to pacify the minds of the wrathful, proud and arrogant nāgas, their jealousy and their desire. If, when I have heard it with the pure divine ear that surpasses the human, I do not bring to faith the nāgas, great nāgas, elder nāgas, nāga children and nāga retinues of the four kinds of birth; if I do not turn back those who have untimely set about dreadful purposes; if I do not then completely pacify the untimely torrential rains and great droughts, the untimely frost, heat and winds, the clouds and the disturbances; if I do not fulfill the wishes of those sentient beings with every requisite of happiness, then may I have deceived all the buddhas, the blessed ones of the three times, and may I myself never fully awaken into unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

"Venerable Blessed One, in the past, in the presence of the Tathāgata Dīpaṃkara and his gathered assembly, I made such a firm aspiration in order to bring sentient beings to maturity, and I have remained utterly steadfast in it. After that too, in the presence of hundreds of thousands of koṭis of niyutas of buddhas, blessed ones, living and dwelling with their gathered assemblies, I made firm aspirations such as this, and I strove, saying, 'There I shall always remain utterly steadfast, with the great diligence that overcomes all

opposition, in order to bring sentient beings to maturity.' Now too, in the presence of the Blessed One, I have made a firm effort to bring the wrathful nāgas to maturity, and for countless eons I have never once, even for an instant, abandoned the diligence I undertook with such firm effort. With constant effort that overcomes all opposition and with firm diligence, I shall bring to maturity once again even those sentient beings whom I have already brought to maturity.

"Furthermore, I have made the lords of the nāgas strive in the conduct of the Great Vehicle: this nāga king Supratiṣṭhita, lord of the elephant nāgas; these two, the nāga kings Nanda and Upananda, lords of the snake nāgas; this nāga king Anavatapta, lord of the horse nāgas; the nāga king Varuṇa, lord of the fish nāgas; and this nāga king Sumanas, lord of the frog nāgas. Nāgas such as these are able to do harm to sentient beings. The other nāga kings like them are also able, each by his own power, to do such harm to sentient beings. Thus, because their respective retinues and hosts of troops untimely carry out such dreadful deeds, all these great kings, who have fully entered the Great Vehicle, will drive away their own retinues."

Because he was acting in this way so that the Blessed One's teaching, the lamp of the Dharma, and the lineage of the Three Jewels would not quickly be cut off, those present in that assembly applauded the bodhisattva great being, the Essence of the Mountain, the sage of the nāgas, saying, "Excellent!"

At that time the nāga king Supratiṣṭhita rose from his seat, bowed with joined palms toward where the Blessed One was, and said, "Venerable Blessed One, wherever they may be, the nāgas and nāga kings who depend on me, those nāgas who are born from eggs, born from the womb, born from heat and moisture, and born miraculously, will have minds of mutual loving-kindness toward the Blessed One's assembly of śrāvakas and assembly of bodhisattvas, and will dwell in that country with minds free of grudges. They will dwell without malice and with minds of equality. The kings of those countries too will come to have minds of great faith in the Blessed One's teaching. They will also uphold the Blessed One's teaching. They will not, through the intoxication and arrogance of power, destroy the Blessed One's teaching. They will not harm monks, nuns, laymen or laywomen. Those who have gone forth for the sake of the Venerable Blessed One, shaved their heads and put on saffron robes, whether they are fit vessels or not, being of superior intention, will also uphold the Blessed One's teaching. Furthermore, they will expel, in accordance with the Dharma, those people in that country who have become thorns to the

Blessed One's teaching.

"Then the virtuous king will not seize the gifts that earlier kings once offered with superior intention to the śramaṇas and brahmins who live on alms in that country; and the virtuous king, together with his ministers, his court priests and his soldiers, gathering the accumulations, will be devoted to what is meaningful. He will have taken hold of the essence. He will give freely with outstretched hand. I shall protect that virtuous king together with his country. I shall care for him completely. In his region I shall drive away all the turmoil of strife and their respective retinues, just as was taught before. Why is that? Because these dyed saffron Dharma robes have been blessed by all the buddhas, the blessed ones of the past.

They are the banner of the bodhisattvas. They are the path of those who go to nirvāṇa. They are the sword against the afflictions. They are the seed of nirvāṇa. They are the lamp for those who have fallen away from the path. They are the medicine for the aggregates. They are the wind that scatters the darkness of ignorance. They are the life-pillar for those in the lower realms. They are the emetic for those ruined by the fault of the afflictions. They are the vajra against enemies. They are the treasury of all roots of virtue. They are the water for those stained by wrongdoing. They are the mirror for those who commit misdeeds. They are meditative absorption for those whose minds are distracted. They are the casket of the meditative absorptions. They are the foundation of the perfections. They are the jewel of the dhāraṇīs. They are the home of patience. They are the vessel of the grounds. They are the fortress against opponents. They are the physician for the sick. They are the mountain of the trainings. They are the moon for those tormented by the afflictions. They are the sun for those who have fallen into wrong views. They are the ocean of wisdom. They have become the garland of the factors of awakening. They are the excellent vase of the wisdom of omniscience. These saffron Dharma robes are like a precious wish-fulfilling jewel. These saffron Dharma robes have been blessed by all the buddhas for the purpose of sending down the rain of the Dharma upon sentient beings.

"Venerable Blessed One, as for those outcaste kings who destroy the Blessed One's teaching and treat monks with violence, and so on, up to those who harm the bodies of those who have gone forth for the sake of the Blessed One, whether they are fit vessels or not, who seize their wealth and who threaten their lives: all the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, rākṣasas, asuras, kumbhāṇḍas and powerful hungry ghosts in that country who have faith in the Buddha will curse

those outcaste kings, and they will bring about quarrels, strife, famine, disease and enemy armies in their country. Although untimely torrential rains, great droughts, frost, heat, wind and the scorching of the sun spoil the seeds, sprouts, leaves, flowers, fruits, grains, medicinal plants and flavors, the nāgas there are not at fault; yet because of it the nāgas there become tainted with infamy.

"Venerable Blessed One, by way of an example: if a fine woman of the land eats bad food, her breath comes to smell foul. In the same way, when outcaste kings abandon the ways of kings and practice the ways of the common folk, everyone from the gods who guard every region up to the powerful hungry ghosts becomes angry. They ruin the country, and the nāgas and great nāgas also become tainted with infamy."

The Blessed One said, "Lords of the nāgas, the kings who are taught to abide in the foundations of royal training are, each of them, striving for the happiness of the higher realms and of nirvāṇa. Those outcaste kings who do not abide in the training of kings are sentient beings headed for the hells, as far down as Avīci. Lords of the nāgas, because you have taught your own retinues not to transgress the training, they will not, in the present time or in the future, bring my teaching and the lineage of the Three Jewels to an end."

The nāga king said, "Venerable Blessed One, so it is. Venerable Sugata, so it is. Venerable Blessed One, in whatever country, in its villages, towns, market towns, provinces and mountain retreats, there live and dwell śrāvakas of the Blessed One who are endowed with moral discipline and great learning, worthy recipients of offerings such as these, if there those of my retinue, the nāgas, nāginīs, elder nāgas, elder nāginīs, nāga sons, nāga daughters, and male and female attendants of the nāgas, untimely send down storms, violent hail, torrential rains and great droughts, or bring about severe frost, intense heat and the scorching of the sun, or make the crops, flowers, fruits, grains, the flavors of medicinal plants, and the enjoyments and provisions of sentient beings thirst for water, then, since those nāgas will have deceived me, may their whole bodies shrivel! May they lose their miraculous powers and be unable to move! May they be tormented by epidemic fevers! May they be deprived of all their enjoyments! May they lose their confidence! May they be unable to accomplish their aims! Thus I shall bind them with an oath.

tadyathā nāgajanduśe nāgamene nāgadharagūghragūghra jalagūghra abimārage sahasramukhe kalatimapuse nāgastambhari jayabaphale

bimuśakrai svāhā

At that very moment the assembly of every kind applauded, saying, "Excellent!" At that same moment the retinues of nāgas of every kind were violently shaken and terrified.

Then the two nāga kings Nanda and Upananda rose from their seats, bowed with joined palms toward where the Blessed One was, and said, "Venerable Blessed One, in the present and in the future, those outcaste kings, having no faith in giving to others and wishing to enjoy things themselves, will be miserly, clinging in their minds to their wealth and never opening their hands, and so will not satisfy the śramaṇas, brahmins, the destitute, the poor, travelers and beggars. Nor will they satisfy the palace retinue, the people of the provinces and their attendants with true happiness. All the gods who guard the regions, the nāgas, yakṣas, rākṣasas, asuras, kumbhāṇḍas and powerful hungry ghosts will become angry with those outcaste kings, and they will bring about quarrels, strife, famine, disease and enemy armies everywhere in their countries.

They spoil the flavors of everything from grains to medicines, and though the nāgas and great nāgas there are not at fault, for that reason the nāgas there are stained with ill repute. Venerable Blessed One, it is like the foul stench of a cesspit: when a breeze stirs it, the stench spreads everywhere. In the same way, Venerable Blessed One, the outcaste kings cause all the guardians of the regions to become angry, and they ruin that country. And the nāgas, too, are stained with ill repute.

The third and final fascicle.

"Or else I shall give instruction to all the nāgas so that they do not transgress my precepts. In whatever countries, in whatever villages, towns, market towns, provinces and mountain retreats of those countries, such śrāvakas of the Blessed One, endowed with moral discipline, very learned and worthy of offerings, dwell now and in the future, if there any of my retinue, nāgas, nāginīs, old male nāgas, old female nāgas, nāga sons, nāga daughters, male nāga attendants and female nāga attendants, whether born from eggs, born from a womb, born from heat and moisture, or born miraculously, send down untimely storms of rain, violent hail, great downpours and great droughts, or bring about great gales, extreme heat and scorching sun, or ruin the crops, flowers, fruits, grains, medicines, flavors, wealth and goods that beings enjoy, then, since those nāgas will have deceived me, may their whole bodies shrivel.

May they be deprived of their miraculous powers and be unable to move. May they be tormented by epidemic fever. May they be deprived of all their wealth. May they lose all confidence. May they be unable to accomplish their aims. Thus I shall bind them by a curse.

tadyathā karnagūme kumbharakṣe barmaguṇe ākalakṣe baiśane bimārgakṣe kunabirage atasale nayantumabhe kālakuśe naṅguprabhe gandharpase svāhā"

Then the whole assembly said, "Excellent!"

Then the nāga king called Anavatapta spoke, as before, up to:

tadyathā nababhiśe nabanamabhiśe ānokṣe nabakuñjabhikṣe khagabaikha saratronanya pāpāyasile narāyaṇaguṇe binastele daśakramai akṣudhāñese ānisabe svāhā

The nāga king called Varuṇa spoke, as before, up to:

tadyathā himabeme palikṣiṇaguṇe ruṇabindutriṇai carakṣadhare meghasaṅkrame byapuṭukeśe drumode māyetanakuse caramahike calaṅge nānādatte kaṭukatūle svāhā

And so on, as before.

At that time the nāga king Sumanas rose from his seat, bowed toward the Blessed One with his palms joined, and said, "Venerable Blessed One, the nāgas and great nāgas who depend on me are born from eggs, born from a womb, born from heat and moisture, and born miraculously. Venerable Blessed One, now and in the future, those outcaste kings will abandon the dharma of the kṣatriya caste and practice the ways of the common caste, and so they are bound for the hells of beings, as far down as Avīci. Through the fault of those outcaste kings the nāgas, though they have done no wrong, are stained with ill repute, and for that reason the nāgas come to create obscurations of karma.

"That being so, we will honor and uphold the word of the Blessed One. It is like a universal monarch who has a fine woman of his land bathed well, anointed with perfumes and dressed in the finest garments, who has many garlands made of the seven precious substances tied upon her head, the best of limbs, has her adorned with armlets, gold threads, rings, bracelets and anklets, sets her upon an elephant for her mount, and leads her forth with a great retinue. In just the same way, now the Tathāgata, the Dharma-possessing universal monarch, has washed us nāgas, whose bodies, gathered into the animal birth,

are whole and unimpaired yet steeped in the stain of fierce anger, pride and arrogance, with the water of the Dharma that is free of the intoxication of vanity. He has clothed us in the garments of shame and conscience. He has bound us with the garland of the thirty-seven factors of awakening. He has richly adorned our minds, our mentation and our consciousness with patience, with dhāraṇīs and with the various grounds. He has lifted us up on the chariots of the Great Vehicle. We are going to where, in a buddha-field free of the five degenerations and utterly pure, the Buddha, the Blessed One, surrounded by a pure assembly of bodhisattvas, teaches pure discourses on the Dharma of the Great Vehicle. Why is that? Because now we honor and uphold the word of the Blessed One.

"That being so, we and our retinues will abide firmly by the word of the Blessed One. In whatever villages, towns, market towns, provinces and mountain retreats there dwell beings of the Śrāvaka Vehicle, the Pratyekabuddha Vehicle or the Great Vehicle, whether householders or those who have gone forth, whether endowed with moral discipline or of corrupt discipline, whether very learned or of little learning, whether diligent or lazy, whether in meditative equipoise or not in equipoise, whether mindful or with mindfulness lapsed, who have joy and faith in the Blessed One, the Dharma, the Saṅgha and the moral discipline that pleases the noble ones, who honor them, esteem them as supreme and revere them, and who have entered upon any one of the three kinds of awakening, wherever such śrāvakas of the Blessed One, worthy of offerings, dwell, there we will dwell with joy and faith in our minds, with honor, esteem and reverence.

"In those countries, in their villages, towns, market towns, provinces and mountain retreats, if any of my retinue, nāgas, nāginīs, old male nāgas, old female nāgas, nāga sons, nāga daughters, male nāga attendants and female nāga attendants, send down untimely storms of rain, violent hail, great downpours and great droughts, or bring about great gales and extreme heat, or ruin the crops, leaves, flowers, fruits, grains, the flavors of medicines, and the wealth and goods that beings enjoy, then, since those nāgas will have deceived me, may the bodies of all of them shrivel. May they lose their miraculous powers and be unable to move. May they be utterly tormented by epidemic fever. May all their faculties be impaired. May they be deprived of all their wealth and goods. May they be unable to do their work.

tadyathā budhajaye bālakṣe amanime bhutasalile anamaṅdhye pratyanile abanilame khilaśome nastupipāle jisajihā skandhapāle bharanikriye svāhā"

Then the entire assembly, as many as had gathered there, their faces and eyes delighted, smiled broadly, joined their palms and said, "Excellent!" They spoke thus: "Holy being, you wish to benefit all beings. Holy being, it is excellent, excellent that you act in this way." When they had said this, that entire assembly of nāgas was violently shaken and terrified; they trembled all over, grew deeply uneasy and milled about.

At that time the gandharva sage called Arising in Joy rose from his seat, bowed toward the Blessed One with his palms joined, and said, "May you and your entire assembly attend to me. Now and in the future there will arise outcaste kings, fools proud in the belief that they are wise, ruined by pride and vanity, heedless of the world beyond, deceitful and without compassion, who insult monks, and who insult even one who, for the Blessed One's sake, has gone for refuge and keeps the observances, who has shaved his head and put on saffron robes. Those outcaste kings who insult those who, for the Blessed One's sake, have gone forth, who are blessed by all the buddhas, and who keep the lineage of the Three Jewels blazing, I shall curse by the power of samādhi, saying: May they be troubled through their wealth. May they be troubled by vassal kings. May they be troubled by the king. May they be troubled by armies within and enemy armies from without. May they be troubled by drought. May they be troubled by disease. May they be troubled by the planets. May they be troubled by birds. May they be troubled by their pastimes. May they be troubled by their kinsmen. May they be troubled by their retinue. May they be troubled by the great elements. May they be troubled by powerful hungry ghosts. And so on, up to: May they be troubled by kṣatriyas. May they be troubled by brahmins, by the common caste, by women, by lions, by tigers and by wolves. Thus shall I curse those outcaste kings.

tadyathā baneya banapale mahābartanatrai drumacchate kusuma baraṭe yugate sambhākṣe bhīmadribākṣe salopanāya paribārai bhūmadrukrame nairantana jasilamenatrai baimabata maśrākhāje nayanahiṅkule pibadcha bhrise dhanamuce saṅgabyokṣai palamindhadalai bhūmipaṣṭe romadalai banagajai tūṭapaṭe āpaṭeḍha nayadriṣṭi jihvākrane utarakṣe gandharbhesimi svāhā

May those outcaste kings who are heedless of the world beyond and who insult the śrāvakas of the Blessed One meet with all this."

At that time the entire assembly of gandharvas said, "Please permit us to do as we will with those outcaste kings who insult the teaching of the Blessed One. If we stay in our own abodes, attached to our amusements and enjoying ourselves, or indulge in pleasures, then may we too fall within the scope of this oath." At that time the entire assembly, as many as had gathered there, said, "Excellent!"

At that time the bodhisattva great being Kṣitigarbha bowed toward the Blessed One with his palms joined and said, "Venerable Blessed One, I too shall teach the great dhāraṇī door called the Banner Pole of the Superknowledge That Plays in All Samādhis. Whoever hears in his ears the great dhāraṇī door called the Banner Pole will have the diseases of his ears pacified. His afflictions, such as attachment, aversion and delusion, will be pacified, or at the least they will be lessened. If one recites these secret mantra words one hundred thousand times over sea-shell and mañjana, and smears this on a royal drum, then whoever hears the sound of that drum will have his afflictions, such as attachment, aversion and delusion, lessened. All of them will come to take great delight in the teaching of the Blessed One, and to honor it, esteem it as supreme and revere it. They will enter upon it by following the Dharma. They will look to the world beyond, will not be parted from wealth and goods, and will be a delight to the eyes and dear to the hearts of all beings.

tadyathā pūrbamārga amalomati kṣittila bhrubaipranakhana ḍaidurmakhilai matsatūlai gaurasandhainakṣubaramai buddharaśmyipiṅgalaghrime lohotārabhe naṅgalasūrye bhagabariṇe andharba ure karahruje keśalohi samādhidhure svāhā"

Then and there the Blessed One gave his approval, saying, "Excellent!" And the entire assembly too said, "Excellent!"

At that time the bodhisattva great being Akṣayamati said, "I wish to teach the great dhāraṇī called the Way of the Aspiration of the Parasol and the Banner, which utters the voice and the sound of all the tathāgatas. Blessed One, may the tathāgatas and their retinues rejoice in me. It is a great light of great might and great power that overcomes all opponents. It will become a treasure that perfects the learning of the śrāvakas of the Blessed One, and a treasure that perfects their wisdom.

"Venerable Blessed One, those who for the Blessed One's sake abide in a vow for as long as they live, that is, who abide in the vow of a layman, the vow of a

novice or the vow of full ordination, whether they are fit vessels or not, if they recite this great dhāraṇī called the Way of the Aspiration of the Parasol and the Banner for seven days and nights while applying themselves to insight, will come to examine the five aggregates of grasping once more. Whoever, when the seven days and nights have passed, calls to mind this great dhāraṇī called the Aspiration of the Parasol and the Banner again and again, as many as a hundred thousand times, will win the faith of kṣatriyas, brahmins, vaiśyas and the common caste, and so on, up to winning the deep faith of all sentient beings. He will never be parted from all supreme and vast wealth and goods, and will be bound for the higher realms. He will be born with a fortune equal to that of the buddhas, the blessed ones, who are present.

tadyathā triṇisaṅñike bitriṇabimabe karaprākṣe bhutasūmeca parajime abhakṣe akṣayalobe adhyadma nimire śrītabistare aṅgujadhajñā jajaranosai anasaśuddhe mṛgaghrikṣe kulabaṭe magabābā kṣebhaubasvare abhitimabhure svarakhajesmṛtimoni svāhā"

Then the Blessed One gave his approval to the bodhisattva Akṣayamati, saying, "Excellent! Holy being, by teaching this great dhāraṇī called the Way of the Aspiration of the Parasol and the Banner, you reveal the eye of learning to countless beings and you also establish my teaching. Excellent, excellent!"

Then and there the entire assembly of bodhisattvas also said to the bodhisattva Akṣayamati, "Excellent!" and spoke thus: "Holy being, by teaching this great dhāraṇī called the Aspiration of the Parasol and the Banner in full, you increase and reveal the great store of learning of all those beings who, now and in the future, have truly entered the Great Vehicle. Excellent, holy being, excellent!"

At that time the youthful Mañjuśrī rose from his seat, bowed toward the Blessed One with his palms joined, and said, "Venerable Blessed One, I too wish to protect the flowers, fruits, trees, grains, medicines and crops of these four continents. I wish to protect the wealth and goods of beings, and the grasses, petals and leaves that depend on the earth. Blessed One, since those in these four continents had never before heard or seen the great dhāraṇī called Naṅgu Glorious Dust, it has now become wondrous and marvelous like this, and has brought about such a Great Assembly as this. This great dhāraṇī called Naṅgu Glorious Dust is of great might, and so it makes all crops flourish. It makes seeds, sprouts, stalks, petals, flowers, fruits, trees, grains, medicines and flavors grow, makes them flourish, makes them rich, makes them soft and

makes them abundant. It makes all beings faithful, makes them disciplined, makes them learned, makes them wise, makes them loving and compassionate, makes them skilled in means, and so on, up to revealing to them all the factors of awakening.

tadyathā ananyabhumi gabākṣabije gulocalome phaṭkṣalome śrīyakṣakusume nabakumuṇḍe rājabarme caṭanaba bamaṭe biṣulaṅge ababhasune hasagabhakṣe lomabhujakṣe gambhirapasume anomayasare palāśatoye svāhā

"Venerable Blessed One, if one ties this great dhāraṇī called Naṅgu Glorious Dust to the top of a banner and raises it up, or proclaims it in a loud voice, or recites these secret mantra words over water a thousand times and sprinkles it on fields, trees and the various crops, or empowers drums, clay drums and conches with it, then wherever their sound is heard, the leaves, flowers, fruits, grains, flavors of medicines and all the crops that depend on the earth, except where the cause, the karmic obscuration of beings' former deeds, remains, cannot be harmed, spoiled, burned, dried up, robbed of their luster, weakened or destroyed by any god, nāga, yakṣa, powerful hungry ghost, māra, son of Māra or host of Māra's retinue. What need, then, to speak of beings and others counted among beings?"

Then the Blessed One gave his approval to the youthful Mañjuśrī, saying, "Excellent! Son of noble family, mounted here in these four continents on the chariot of the glory of great generosity, son of noble family, you establish countless beings here on the path to unsurpassed awakening. Son of noble family, excellent, excellent!"

Then and there the entire assembly of bodhisattvas also said to the youthful Mañjuśrī, "Excellent! Son of noble family, it is excellent, excellent that you act in this way."

At that time the bodhisattva great being Avalokiteśvara said to the bodhisattva Maitreya,

"Maitreya, I shall give you the great dhāraṇī called Glorious Fresh Flower. Son of noble family, through that great dhāraṇī, when you have put on the armor of great love and teach the Dharma to beings here in words, then whatever beings hear those teachings, which produce the power of the miraculous displays of samādhi, will give up evil thoughts and evil views. They will give up evil companions and evil friends. In their minds they will attend to love, compassion and the roots of virtue. They will feel tenderness for all beings,

and their minds will look to the world beyond. Their minds will turn away from the ten paths of nonvirtuous action. Their minds will abide in the ten paths of virtuous action. Their minds will delight in all beings. This great dhāraṇī sends down a rain of Dharma in order to fulfill the wishes of all beings. It makes all enemies deeply faithful and makes all friends increase.

tadyathā libatasvare kāśāya barme samebagghe dvāraṅgajale sutokṣe sumahābhakṣare suhabuṅge gau abalokadale siddhibhibakṣe dhyananbībare abinadhaluṅbe socaracala ababhasare barāhaśatte ekahādatoye samādhikaraṇe bālajabiti mahādābhutakuse araṇanile mālāmaśame nilakusume svāhā

"This is the dhāraṇī called Glorious Fresh Flower. Bodhisattva great being, when you have put on the armor of great love and teach the Dharma to beings, its sound calms the turbidity of mind of whatever beings hear it, even the tiniest of creatures, and their minds come to abide in the roots of virtue. What need, then, to speak of those born as humans?

"Some beings, in order to bring rain, may recite this great dhāraṇī at the abodes of gandharvas and nāgas. Let them mix powdered pepper with castor oil, empower it with the dhāraṇī a thousand times, tie it in a knot at the hem of a cloth and put it in a well. Then the nāgas will be pleased with it and will send down great streams of rain."

At that time the nāgas and great nāgas gathered in that land heard this great dhāraṇī called Glorious Fresh Flower, and their minds became content, free of hostility, full of joy and endowed with love, and their minds came to look to the world beyond. Their minds gained faith in the Three Jewels, and honor, esteem and reverence for them. Their minds sincerely confessed their own evil deeds, which had caused their birth as animals, and their minds came to abide in entering the unsurpassed Great Vehicle. All those nāgas and great nāgas, with whatever might they had and whatever they could do, made offerings to the Blessed One there. Some sent down a rain of much gold. Others sent down rains of silver, aloeswood, saffron, gośīrṣa sandalwood, powdered uraga-sāra sandalwood and tamāla leaves, and so on, up to others who sent down rains of blue lotuses, various flowers, various fine fabrics, parasols, banners, various pennants, gold threads and pearl necklaces.

Then all those nāgas and great nāgas bowed toward the Blessed One with their palms joined and said with one voice, "Venerable Blessed One, now our minds have entered fully and well into the Three Jewels. Venerable Blessed

One, in the presence of the Blessed One we make this pledge. Venerable Blessed One, in whatever villages, towns, market towns and provinces this great dhāraṇī called Glorious Fresh Flower is proclaimed, and likewise the other dhāraṇīs, the one called the Essence of the Water Palace, the one called Power of Weapons, the one called the Way of the Aspiration of the Parasol and the Banner, the one called Naṅgu Glorious Dust and the great dhāraṇī called Glorious Fresh Flower, together with the dhāraṇīs spoken by the Four Great Kings and the four nāga essences, in whatever villages, towns, market towns, provinces and mountain retreats even a single one of them is taught, explained, proclaimed or called to mind, there we shall send down rain, sunshine and breezes in their proper seasons, and never out of season. There we shall fully pacify foreign enemies, internal strife, quarrels, disputes, malice, disease, misfortune and famine. There we shall bring about happiness, good harvests and joy. There we shall make the seeds, sprouts, stalks, petals, flowers, fruits, trees, grains, medicines and flavors of beings flourish without decline. We shall make most of their wealth and goods fragrant, delicious, rich and soft. We shall also cause the kings of this Jambudvīpa to hold toward one another thoughts of love, thoughts of help, thoughts free of enmity and thoughts free of dispute. Likewise we shall cause brahmins, vaiśyas, the common caste, and so on from yakṣas up to laymen, to be endowed with thoughts of love. Wherever this great dhāraṇī is proclaimed, we shall cause all to be of one mind with one another."

Then the Blessed One gave his approval to all those nāgas, saying, "Excellent, excellent!" And the entire assembly, as many as had gathered there, also said, "Excellent!" Then the bodhisattva Essence of the Mountain also said, "Excellent!" Then the Blessed One spoke to the great goddess Śrī:

"Śrī, Knower of Rites, since you have these compassionate friends, why are you still unable to bring the hosts of those to be trained in here, so as to bring beings to maturity?"

The great goddess Śrī replied, "Through the distinction of his aspirations, that bodhisattva great being takes birth in this way in all the buddha-fields that are marked by the five degenerations, and he has come to meet such harmonious companions and virtuous friends. Now I too have met a harmonious companion and virtuous friend such as you. Unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening is within his reach, and his six perfections, too, are to be proclaimed. A bodhisattva great being who is cared for by a virtuous friend and has undertaken diligence should be seen as firmly established in the

wisdom of omniscience."

The Blessed One said, "Śrī, Knower of Rites, it is just as you say. Through the distinction of his aspirations, that bodhisattva great being takes birth in this way in all the buddha-fields that are marked by the five degenerations in order to bring beings to maturity. He strives in the four means of attraction, is steadfast in that striving, and has undertaken diligence. He is cared for by such companions and virtuous friends. The wisdom that knows all aspects is within his reach, and his complete six perfections are also to be proclaimed. His vanquishing, too, is to be proclaimed. His freedom from the faults of the womb, too, is to be proclaimed. His exhaustion of the defilements through abiding on the ground of no more learning, too, is to be proclaimed. That all the buddhas, the blessed ones, keep him in mind and bless him, too, is to be proclaimed. That he is firmly established on the ground free of attachment, too, is to be proclaimed."

Then Śakra Vimalatejas bowed toward the Blessed One with his palms joined and said, "Venerable Blessed One, why is it that in this world of the living the nāgas and great nāgas harm the wealth and goods of beings?"

The Blessed One said, "Lord of the gods, it is through two causes and conditions that in this world of the living the nāgas and great nāgas harm the wealth and goods of beings. What are the two? Under the power of desire and under the power of anger, they make untimely clouds arise and send down storms of rain and violent hail. They bring about gales and heat. Thereby they burn the seeds, sprouts, petals, flowers, fruits, grains, medicines and flavors of beings here. They dry them up. They make them rot. They make them spoiled. Thereby beings, lacking wealth and goods, commit all kinds of terrible evil deeds of body, speech and mind. Through those terrible obscurations of karma they burn up all the roots of virtue they had produced before. They dry them up. They reduce them to ashes. They give up their virtuous friends and are bound for the three lower realms. Some, merely for the sake of clothing, food and drink, commit in a single lifetime such evil deeds, up to the deeds of immediate retribution, and for many eons will not again obtain a human birth. Even if, after a long time, by a chance of one in a hundred, they obtain a human body, some will have impaired limbs. Some will have impaired mindfulness. They will be born in caṇḍāla families. They will be born in families of outcastes, of bamboo workers, and of the destitute and poor. They will be deprived of wealth and goods in food and drink, and for that very reason, parted from virtuous friends, they will commit terrible obscurations of karma in

body, speech and mind. And some will be bound for the three lower realms and for Avīci. Son of noble family, in this way beings who lack wealth and goods are afflicted for a long time in saṃsāra. In the three lower realms they experience all kinds of terrible suffering."

He said, "All suffering, whatever arises, comes about from the condition of food. Where there is no food, no suffering arises either."

Then at that time Śakra Vimalatejas spoke these verses:

"Transformed by the poison of craving,
They weep and they laugh,
They draw near and they fall,
They indulge and they run wild.

Like sesame pounded upon the ground,
The machine of suffering does harm;
In just this way craving harms
The whole world with its gods.

Alas! The noose of existence
Reaches to the very Peak of Existence;
This noose, so vast,
Has arisen from the cause of food.

Ordinary beings, by the two causes,
Have their limbs bound by the dust of craving;
Like deer bound in a snare,
They are unable to flee.

As beings of the world with its gods
Strive in the dance that craving makes them dance,
Not even a hundred dancers following the treatises of dance
Could strive so hard in dancing.

As people are intoxicated
When transformed by the poison of craving,
No adulterated intoxicating drink
Could make them so intoxicated.

As people seized by the yakṣa demons of craving
Rave in delirium,
Those maddened by the demons of the bhūtas
Do not rave so.

Those who have let go of holding on to wealth
And have wholly cast off the fear of craving,
Those who have dried up craving,
Do not remain in saṃsāra."

The bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara also said:

"Beings are overwhelmed by aversion and wrath,
And because of this their minds are distracted;
They do not seek any virtue at all
And engage in deeds that destroy patience.

Abiding in what is unwholesome,
They show little service to father and mother;
Those who have committed the deeds of immediate retribution
Hold the Three Jewels in contempt.

Without love and without compassion,
Terrifying, fierce, and violent,
Under the power of their wrathful minds
They dwell in the Avīci hell.

Because of wrath these beings
Devour one another,
And again and again in the lower realms
They are tormented by many sufferings.

Led astray by evil minds,
Having forsaken their spiritual friends,
They fall into the ocean of existence,
Heading from darkness into deeper darkness.

For the sake of beings such as these,
Bodhisattvas, with loving intent,
Give up their own happiness,
And when, to clear away the evil of beings,
They practice the conduct of awakening,
Through the three bases of meritorious action
They free beings who have done evil
And raise high the banner of the Dharma.

For the sake of even a few beings
They give up body and life,

And, devoted to austerities and vows,
They perform many hardships.

When, for the sake of a few beings,
They would remove suffering for a hundred eons,
For the sake of beings, for a long time,
They patiently bear suffering in saṃsāra.

They remain in order to bring beings to maturity.
Endowed with such an intention,
They turn toward awakening the minds
Of beings whose thoughts are set on existence."

Then the great goddess Śrī offered the measuring vessel filled with grain to the bodhisattva mahāsattva Avalokiteśvara and said, "So that all seeds and crops may increase and come to fruition, as the cause of the enjoyments and the provisions of the beings of this world of four continents, I offer this bowl to you, holy being. With it you are able to free from all suffering all those who have utterly cut off their roots of virtue, the savage, the fierce, and the violent, and to establish them in the seed of awakening."

Then the bodhisattva mahāsattva, the noble Avalokiteśvara, took the measuring vessel filled with grain, looked toward the ten directions, and spoke these words: "May all the buddhas, the blessed ones, and the bodhisattva mahāsattvas, together with their retinues, turn their attention here! So that in this world of four continents seeds, sprouts, leaves, flowers, fruits, grains, medicines, flavors, the essence of the earth, vigor, the vigor of beings, the taste of the sublime Dharma, the kernel, and splendor may not decline but increase; so that the lamp of the sublime Dharma and the lineage of the Three Jewels may not be cut off; so that through all those enjoyments and provisions beings may be brought to maturity, turned back from evil, and be able to be set in the awakening mind; so that all those beings here may wholly abandon the lower realms and head toward the higher realms; and so that the intention of the great goddess Śrī may be completely fulfilled: may all the tathāgatas without exception who dwell, abide, and live in the ten directions turn their attention here!

tadyathā muni śiba muni natre muni pala muni sale santa usakṣiti kṣanu praṇa nīla baya ba sarba bīja basti lali svāhā"

Then the Blessed One gave his approval, saying, "Excellent!" and said to the great goddess Śrī, "Śrī, Knower of Rites, so that you may increase seeds, sprouts, and crops in this world of four continents and bring beings to maturity, you are blessed by all the buddhas, the blessed ones, together with their assembled retinues, without exception."

Then Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, Kauśika, said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, what is the name of this Dharma discourse? How should this Dharma discourse be retained?"

The Blessed One said, "It is called The Pledge of the Tathāgata's Glory. It is called The Questions of the Essence of the Mountain. It is called The Casket of Dhāraṇīs. It is called The Increase of the Essence of the Earth. It is called The Yoga of Meditative Absorption That Brings Beings to Maturity."

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the great goddess Śrī, the Essence of the Mountain, the bodhisattva mahāsattva, and the entire assembly rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

This completes the Great Vehicle sūtra called The Pledge of the Tathāgata's Glory, from the Great Vehicle sūtra collection of the Great Assembly.

It was translated, edited, and finalized by the Indian preceptor Sarvajñādeva and the chief editor-translator, the monk Paltsek.

ye dharmā hetu prabhabā hetunte ṣānta thāgato hya badrat teṣāñca yo nirodha ebaṃ bādī mahāśramaṇaḥ maṅgalaṃ

Here is contained the Sūtra section, volume Wa.

Translator's Notes

• The setting is obscure. The mountain called ri ther sgra is not securely identified (it may correspond to a known Mahāsaṃnipāta site such as Khadiraka), so it is given as Mount Thersgra. The phrase rendered "where the boundless and limitless Bṛhaspati of the Great Brahmā received his prophecy" takes phur bu as the planet-deity Bṛhaspati (Jupiter); the construction is uncertain. In the title, dpal ("glory," Skt. śrī) may refer to the goddess Śrī, who is the interlocutor, so the title could also be understood as "The Pledge of Śrī before the Tathāgata." The Buddha's address dpal cho ga shes is taken as an epithet of the goddess, "Śrī, Knower of Rites"; its Sanskrit form is not certain. The "five limbs" possessed and the "five" abandoned are the factors of the first dhyāna and the five hindrances.
• "Conceptual thought" and "analysis" render rnam par rtog pa and rnam par dpyod pa, here the technical dhyāna factors vitarka and vicāra (applied and sustained thought). The verb sel ba, rendered "picks out," is unusual in this context and its exact sense is uncertain. The "samādhi of aspiration" (smon pa'i ting nge 'dzin) stands where the standard triad of emptiness, signlessness and wishlessness would lead one to expect "wishlessness" (smon pa

med pa); the text is translated as it stands. The opening sentence of the Buddha's reply ("So it runs, from ... up to ...") is an abbreviation formula in the Tibetan indicating that the stock dialogue is to be supplied.

• "Certainty of the śrāvakas" renders nyan thos kyi nges pa, the irreversible entry (niyāma) into the śrāvaka path. "Well-performed conduct" renders las kyi mtha' legs par spyad pa, likely right conduct (samyakkarmānta). The closing lines contrast the five limbs abandoned and possessed in the dhyānas with five limbs that bind one to the three realms; the exact referents are not specified in this piece.

• The chapter colophon calls this the first chapter, although the chapter list for the text numbers the following one as the second; "Essence of the Mountain" renders ri'i snying po, the name of the larger section of the Great Assembly from which this text is drawn. The "fixed certainty" (nges pa) is the irreversible entry into the śrāvaka path. The number of pores, 'bum phrag khrag khrig dgu bcu rtsa dgu, is rendered "ninety-nine hundred thousand niyutas," taking khrag khrig as niyuta; the exact value intended is uncertain. The "nine doors of the wounds" are the nine bodily orifices.

• The opening clause (literally "where beings ... experience various sufferings") is left as the text has it; it introduces the bodhisattva's resolve and does not depend on anything missing. The repeated phrase "within the bounds I have set" renders □□□□□□□□□□□, the delimited area or set of beings that the aspiration covers.

• The opening □□□□□□□□□ is read as □□□□□□□□□□ ("that bodhisattva ... makes an aspiration"), matching the parallel formula in the previous passage. In the first meditative concentration the five factors possessed are applied thought, sustained thought, joy, bliss and one-pointedness, and the five abandoned are the five hindrances, according to the standard Abhidharma account; the text itself names neither list.

• The large number rendered "a hundred billion" translates □□□□□□□□, one of the high powers of ten in the Tibetan counting system; its exact value varies between lists. The layman's name □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ has been translated literally ("Stainless Star Glory") because its Sanskrit form could not be identified with confidence; his son's name □□□□□□□□□□□ is the standard rendering of Vimalaśrī. The phrase □□□□□□□□□□□ ... □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ marks an abridgment in the text itself, rendered "and so on, up to".

• The name of the dhāraṇī, □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, is translated literally ("the Prosperity-Bringing Essence of the Water Mansion"), since its Sanskrit form could not be identified with confidence; □□□□□□□ may mean a rain-cloud or an astrological mansion. The dhāraṇī is transliterated as the Tibetan spells it. The short sentence □□□□□□□□□□□□ at the end of the first fascicle is terse; it is rendered "I shall bring them to faith." The speaker throughout is the great goddess Śrī, addressing Kṣitigarbha as "son of noble family" and reporting the words of the past Tathāgata.

• The phrase □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is obscure; it is rendered "falling in with the deceitful." □□□□□□□□□□□ is taken as the standard rendering of pūtana, a class of malignant spirit. □□□□□□□ is the Sahā world, the world system of Śākyamuni.

• The opening speech continues the words of the bodhisattva in the preceding passage, addressed to Śrī, Knower of Rites. Several goddess names could not be identified with confidence and are translated by meaning: □□□□□□□□ (Light-Maker), □□□□□□□□□□□□ (Splendid One), □□□□□□□ (Virtuous One), □□□□□□□□ (Sun-Self), □□□□□□ (Crystal One); □□□□□□ is the earth goddess Dṛḍhā. □□□□□□□□ is taken as the large number ten quadrillion (10^16), so the retinue is eighty hundred thousand of that unit. In the verse, □□□□□□□□ ("become faithful") is read as □□□□□□□□□□ ("become clear"), since it describes turbid rivers. Because □□□□□□□□□□□ has already been fixed as "pūtana", the separate class □□□□□□□ listed just before it is rendered "foul spirits" to keep the two distinct.

• The speaker of the words after the second dhāraṇī ("Śrī, Knower of Rites, that is the great

dhāraṇī...") is not named; the plain, non-humble verbs suggest it is Kṣitigarbha addressing the goddess rather than the Buddha. The phrase □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is obscure; it is rendered as pains in the belly afflicting those who seek food, taking □□ as □□□ "belly". The name □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is translated by meaning (Power of Weapons), as its Sanskrit form cannot be identified with confidence.

• The words "and so on, up to" render the Tibetan's abbreviation (□□ ... □□□□□), which refers back to a fuller passage given earlier in the sūtra. The name of the absorption, □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, is rendered "the Abode of the Haughty Nāgas"; □□□□□□□ could also be taken as "subdued" or "stretched out", so its exact sense is uncertain.

• The nāga king □□□□□□□□ is taken as Sumanas, the usual Sanskrit equivalent of □□□□□□□. The phrase □□ is read as the converted nāga kings driving away their own retinues that cause harm; □□□□□□ could also mean simply "set in motion", so the sense is not fully certain. □□□□□□□□□□, here referring to a ruler, is rendered "king".

• The opening sentences continue the description of the saffron Dharma robes from the preceding passage. In the Buddha's reply, □□□□□□□□□□□□□ ("my own retinue") makes poor sense addressed to the nāga lords; it is read as □□□□□□□□□□□□□□ ("your own retinues"), a likely copyist's slip. The words "and so on, up to" render the Tibetan's abbreviation (□□ ... □□□□□) of a passage given earlier. The nāga king who answers the Buddha is not named here; from context he is Supratiṣṭhita.

• "Untimely storms of rain" renders □□□□□□□□, literally "goatherd rain", an obscure term for some damaging kind of rain. "Ruin" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, whose exact sense is unclear; the context requires damage to crops and goods, possibly by flooding. The formula "up to as before" indicates that the speeches of Anavatapta and Varuṇa repeat the preceding vow, which the text abbreviates.

• The gandharva sage's name, Arising in Joy, translates □□□□□□□□□□□□□□; its Sanskrit form (perhaps Nandodbhava or similar) cannot be identified with confidence. Two items in the list of troubles are obscure: □□□□□□□ is rendered "birds" and □□□□□□ "their pastimes", both tentatively. "Sea-shell and mañjana" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□; the sea-shell is probably cuttlefish bone, and mañjana is left as transliterated, its identity uncertain.

• The dhāraṇī name □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is rendered "Naṅgu Glorious Dust": "glorious dust" translates □□□□□□□□ (perhaps Śrīreṇu or similar), while □□□□□ appears to be a transliterated Indic element that cannot be identified with confidence. In Akṣayamati's speech, the dhāraṇī is said to lead the practitioner to examine the five aggregates of grasping "once more"; □□□□ may instead mean "in order to", but the sense, sustained contemplation of the aggregates through insight, is the same.

• The dhāraṇī's name is spelled □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ ("Glorious Fresh Flower") throughout, but once □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ ("Glorious Yellow Flower"); it is rendered uniformly as the same dhāraṇī. "The Essence of the Water Palace" translates □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, a dhāraṇī named earlier in the sūtra, whose Sanskrit form is uncertain. In the rain rite, □□□□□□□ is taken as pepper and □□□□□□□□□□□□ as castor oil (eraṇḍa).

• In the Blessed One's praise of the bodhisattva, "his vanquishing" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□, presumably his conquest of Māra and the afflictions. The prose remark that all suffering arises from the condition of food is introduced only by "he said", without naming the speaker; the following verses suggest it is Śakra. "Bound for the three lower realms" and similar phrases render □□□□□□, "inclined toward, headed for". In the last stanza, □□□□□□□□ is taken as "holding on to wealth"; it could also be read as the name Vasundharā, which would make the line an address, but the plain reading fits the stanza better.

• The line rendered "they dwell in the Avīci hell" reads literally "they dwell in mind-hell Avīci"; the initial "mind" is taken as continuing "their wrathful minds" of the previous line. The "three bases of meritorious action" are traditionally giving, ethical discipline, and meditation. The

vessel is first called a measure (bre bo) and then, in Śrī's words, a bowl (lhung bzed).

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.